

What else to watch: *Destination Moon* (1950) ■ *The Day the Earth Stood Still* (1951) ■ *Planet of the Apes* (1968) ■ *Close Encounters of the Third Kind* (1977) ■ *Alien* (1979, p.243) ■ *Gravity* (2013, p.326) ■ *Interstellar* (2014)

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The picture that science-fiction fans of every age and in every corner of the world have prayed (sometimes forlornly) that the industry might some day give them.

Charles Champlin
Los Angeles Times, 1970

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role in the universe. *2001*'s opening scene centers on Moon-Watcher, a prehistoric ape whose tribe is fighting another for water and comes into contact with a mysterious black object known as the Monolith. The appearance of the Monolith triggers a shift in the apes' culture; they turn old bones into tools—and weapons—and the human race's long journey to the stars begins in earnest.

From ape to astronaut

This odyssey is represented by a now iconic cut from one image to another, as a bone hurled by Moon-Watcher becomes a spaceship twirling through the void. Suddenly the action shifts to the future, where astronauts Bowman (Keir Dullea) and Poole (Gary Lockwood) are on a mission to Jupiter in the spaceship *Discovery*. Their lives are in the care of *Discovery*'s computer, HAL 9000 (voiced with chilling detachment by Douglas Rain), who malfunctions and grows politely mutinous. When the crew try to shut him down, HAL fights back. “I’m sorry, Dave,” he tells

Douglas Trumbull Special effects supervisor

Douglas Trumbull was just 23 years old when he started working on the special effects for *2001*. He had come to Stanley Kubrick's attention for his work on a documentary about space flight called *To the Moon and Beyond*. He was one of four special effects supervisors on *2001*, and was responsible for creating the psychedelic star gate sequence. He went on

to win Oscars for his work on *Close Encounters of the Third Kind*, *Star Trek: The Motion Picture* (1979), and *Blade Runner*.

Key movies

1968 *2001: A Space Odyssey*
1972 *Silent Running*
1977 *Close Encounters of the Third Kind*
1982 *Blade Runner*

Bowman when given an order. “I’m afraid I can’t do that.” Here Kubrick is showing the audience another turning point in humanity’s evolution—the point at which the tools begin to turn on the apes.

Mystery and meaning

As *Discovery*'s mission descends further and further into disaster, the Monolith appears again. What can it mean? Is it the emissary of an alien race? Proof of the existence of God? The scientists are baffled, and so is the viewer. Kubrick refuses to supply any easy answers; he’s more interested in taking the audience on a journey than he is in revealing the destination.

The final act of *2001* abandons conventional storytelling as the audience follows Bowman through a tunnel of light and into an otherworldly chamber, possibly the construct of an extraterrestrial host, where the Monolith is waiting for him. He sees himself as an old man

Bowman finally finds himself alone in the space pod. Time appears to become warped as an older version of himself appears, followed at the end of the movie by the fetuslike Star Child.

and is then transformed into the Star Child, a strange, fetal being floating in space—and this is where the movie ends. As a final image, the Star Child is both obscure and crystal clear. We don’t know what it is, or how it came to be, or where it is going, but we know what it means: hope, and the beginning of another journey for our species. ■

